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Three waterfronts. A fifteen-minute life.

Bunbury is the city at the heart of Western Australia’s South West: a relaxed port city two hours south of Perth, with an ocean surf coast, a calm bay where wild dolphins live and a wide estuary all inside the city limits. Clinicians come for a referral hospital with a case mix far broader than the city’s size, and stay for short commutes, room to live and some of Australia’s loveliest weekend country on the doorstep.

~75,000

people across Greater Bunbury

~2 hrs

by road to Perth

~15 min

most trips across the city

~30 min

to the Ferguson Valley wine country

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Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Why clinicians choose Bunbury

Most people who move here are swapping a big-city commute for more coastline, more time and more responsibility at work. Bunbury makes that swap easy, and keeps Perth within a comfortable drive.

“

If you're looking for a big-city department with a subspecialty team of thirty, Bunbury may not be it. If you're drawn to real clinical breadth, a ten-minute drive to work and a beach at the end of the day, it could be a wonderful choice.

Bunbury is Western Australia's largest city outside the Perth metropolitan area, home to around 75,000 people across Greater Bunbury. It sits on a peninsula on the Indian Ocean coast, about 175 kilometres south of Perth, with Koombana Bay to the north and the Leschenault Estuary curving behind it. It grew up as a port, and the port still works, which is why the city has the infrastructure of a much bigger place: a regional referral hospital, a university campus, a regional theatre and art gallery, and a farmers' market people happily drive an hour to reach.

For clinicians the attraction is specific. The city's main public hospital is the referral centre for the whole South West, a region of towns, farms, forests and coast, so the work arriving at your door is broader and more varied than a city of this size would usually generate. Alongside it sits a genuine private sector, including the South West's only PET service. You get regional responsibility without remoteness: Perth's tertiary centres are a two-hour drive away, not a flight.

And then there is the life around the work. Surf on one side of town, flat water on the other, an estuary for kayaking and crabbing, and the vineyards of the Ferguson Valley half an hour inland. Busselton, Dunsborough and Margaret River, the places other Western Australians drive four hours to reach for a holiday, are your ordinary weekends.

WHAT YOU GAIN

Breadth and earlier responsibility

Work comes in from across the South West, and smaller specialist teams mean your judgement is trusted and your name is on decisions sooner.

Time back every day

Most commutes are ten to fifteen minutes, with easy parking. Over a year that is weeks of your life returned.

A home with room

Housing costs noticeably less than in Perth, and far less than Sydney or Melbourne, so one clinical salary stretches a long way.

Three coastlines in one city

Ocean surf, a calm bay and an estuary, each a few minutes from home. You never have to choose.

GOOD TO KNOW

A close-knit specialist team

Depth exists in most specialties, but as a handful of colleagues rather than a large department. Ask how many people sit alongside you in your area.

Perth for the most complex work

The most specialised cases are referred north to the capital, a normal and well-worn pathway. Which cases depends on your specialty, so it is a great interview question.

Plan your first month's home

The rental market moves with the region's big industrial projects, so arriving with somewhere secured for the first few weeks takes the pressure off.

A regional city's pace

Bunbury has a theatre, galleries and good coffee, and a friendly, know-your-neighbours feel. For a big concert or a long-haul flight, Perth is two hours up the road.



Looking over Bunbury's streets to the ocean from the hill above Marlston

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Weighing up your options?

People often compare Bunbury with Perth, for a large tertiary system and the capital's lifestyle, and with Mandurah, for waterside living closer to the city. If you need a big subspecialty team around you, Perth may suit you best, and it is close enough that Bunbury can still be a later move. If you are drawn to regional breadth, short commutes and the South West on your doorstep, Bunbury is hard to beat. We are always happy to talk the options through.

IN SHORT

- ✓ A referral centre's case mix in a friendly city of 75,000.
- ✓ Ten to fifteen minutes to work, and Perth two hours away when you want it.
- ✓ Surf, bay, estuary and wine country, all part of an ordinary week.



Surf lessons start young on the ocean side of town



Beach days with the family, minutes from home



A surf after work is an ordinary weekday here



Good coffee is easy to find in Bunbury



Unhurried mornings before a late shift

A port city between ocean, bay and estuary

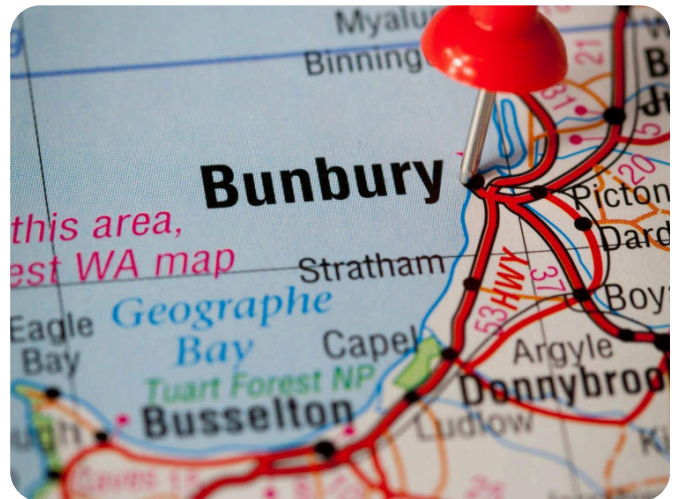
Bunbury makes sense the moment you see its shape: a compact centre on a peninsula with water on three sides. Where you live, which beach you use and how you spend a Sunday all follow from that.

The Indian Ocean runs down the city's western edge, with surf beaches, basalt rocks and dunes. To the north is Koombana Bay, sheltered water beside the port and the Marlston waterfront, where a resident population of wild bottlenose dolphins feeds and plays. Behind the city lies the Leschenault Estuary, calm and shallow, edged with the southernmost mangroves in Western Australia.

The centre is small and walkable, with the waterfront, cafés, the entertainment centre and the art gallery all close together. Suburbs spread south along the coast towards Dalyellup and Gelorup, and north-east across the estuary to Eaton and Australind. Beyond the city edge the land rises gently into farmland, forest and the green hills of the Ferguson Valley.



The city centre and waterfront at dusk, with the Indian Ocean beyond



Bunbury on the map: the gateway to Geographe Bay, Busselton and the South West

175 km

south of Perth
about two hours on the
Forrest Highway

~75,000

people in Greater Bunbury
the largest urban centre in
WA outside Perth

3

waterfronts
ocean, bay and estuary

Summer

DEC – FEB

Warm to hot, dry and sunny, with highs usually around the high twenties to low thirties. The afternoon sea breeze arrives most days, so mornings are for the ocean beaches and afternoons for the calm bay.

Autumn

MAR – MAY

Many locals' favourite season: warm water, settled days and quieter beaches once the summer visitors have gone home.

Winter

JUN – AUG

Mild and green, with daytime highs in the high teens. This is the rainy season, when fronts roll in off the Indian Ocean, the estuary fills and the inland valleys turn lush.

Spring

SEP – NOV

Wildflowers inland, whales passing offshore and the first swims of the year by November.

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Good to know about the winter

The South West is the green, rain-fed corner of a dry state, and its wet season is real. A good raincoat, a warm, dry home and an indoor plan for wet weekends make June to August cosy rather than grey; it is also when the forests, waterfalls and wineries are at their most beautiful.



Wardandi Noongar Country

TENS OF THOUSANDS OF YEARS

Bunbury is Goomburrup, on Wardandi Noongar Country in the south-west of the Noongar nation. The coast, estuary and rivers have been cared for by Wardandi people for millennia.



A port on the bay

1830S ONWARDS

European settlement grew around the sheltered anchorage of Koombana Bay, and the port has been the city's reason for being ever since.



Timber, minerals and alumina

20TH CENTURY

Jarrah and karri, then mineral sands and alumina, flowed out through Bunbury, funding the roads, rail and services the region relies on.



A city that faces the water

TODAY

The waterfront has been rebuilt for people, a university campus has arrived, and Bunbury serves the whole South West as its administrative, retail and clinical centre.

Acknowledging Country

- ✓ Bunbury sits on Wardandi Noongar Country. The Noongar name for this place is Goomburrup.
- ✓ Acknowledgements of Country open meetings and events across the region, and it is warmly appreciated when newcomers take time to learn whose Country they live and work on.
- ✓ Look out for local Noongar-led tours, art and NAIDOC Week events: a lovely way to begin understanding the place.



Busselton, the next town south along Geographe Bay, about 45–50 minutes from Bunbury

Healthcare and work in Bunbury

Bunbury's clinical role is bigger than its population, for one simple reason: it is where the South West sends its patients. Understanding that referral role is the key to understanding the work.

Public healthcare in regional Western Australia is delivered by the state's country health service. In Bunbury that means the region's main public hospital, a modern health campus that acts as the referral centre for the South West. It takes patients from district hospitals in the surrounding towns and provides the specialist services those towns do not carry, including emergency, acute medicine and surgery, maternity, paediatrics, mental health, critical care, imaging and cancer services.

Around it sits a well-developed private sector, with private hospital, imaging and specialist services, including the only PET service anywhere in the South West, plus general practice, community health and Aboriginal community-controlled health services across the region. For the most complex work, Perth's tertiary hospitals are two hours north, and transfers, phone consults and telehealth links with them are an everyday part of how the region works.



A referral centre sees work from across the South West, so no two days look the same



Imaging in the South West spans both public and private services, with a wide range of modalities

THE WHOLE SOUTH WEST

A regional referral centre

Presentations arrive from towns across the region, so your case mix is broader than the city's own population would suggest.

A CONNECTED NETWORK

District hospitals around it

Smaller hospitals in the surrounding towns manage local care and refer inward when a patient needs the specialist team.

PRIVATE HOSPITAL · IMAGING · SPECIALISTS

A strong private sector

Private services work alongside the public system, including nuclear medicine and the region's only PET-CT.

~2 HRS NORTH

Perth as the tertiary partner

The most complex work goes to the capital's tertiary centres, with well-established transfer and advice pathways.

For imaging professionals in particular, Bunbury is an interesting place to work. Radiographers, sonographers and nuclear medicine technologists here are more likely to work across several modalities than in a large metropolitan department where the work is divided up, and cross-training tends to be genuinely available because a regional service values people who can cover more than one room.

Registration is national through Ahpra, but pay is set state by state. Public-sector pay follows the relevant Western Australian health industrial agreement for your profession; private-sector pay is negotiated with the employer and can be higher for hard-to-fill roles. Regional roles may also come with extra support, so it is always worth asking.



In a regional service you get to know your colleagues across every department

What to ask at interview

- ☐ How far does this service's referral catchment reach, and how much outreach or telehealth is involved?
- ☐ Which cases go to Perth in my specialty, and how is that handled day to day?
- ☐ How many colleagues work alongside me in my specialty specifically?
- ☐ What is the on-call pattern, and how often is it called upon?
- ☐ Which modalities or sub-specialties would I cover, and is cross-training supported?
- ☐ What CPD time and funding is offered, and does it include travel to Perth for courses?
- ☐ Is there relocation support or regional assistance, such as help with temporary housing?



Continuity of care: in a regional city you often see patients again



Paediatric work comes in from right across the South West



Maternity care for families across the region



Primary care and specialists work closely together here



Overseas-trained clinicians are a familiar, welcome part of the team

Where to live in Bunbury

Nowhere in Greater Bunbury is a long commute, which frees you to choose on lifestyle. The real question is which water you would like to live beside: the ocean, the bay or the estuary.

Start with your workplace. The city's clinical sites are not all in one spot, and while almost everything is within about fifteen minutes, it is lovely to know whether you are choosing a five-minute or a twenty-minute drive before you sign a lease.

Then pick your side. The ocean side means surf, sea breezes and sunsets; the bay side means flat water, the waterfront and the city centre; across the estuary and inland you will find the newest family homes and the most space for your money.

WALKABLE · WATERFRONT

City centre & Marlston

Apartments and townhouses close to Koombana Bay, cafés, restaurants and the entertainment centre. Lovely for singles and couples who want to walk to dinner on a Friday.

~5-10 MIN · OCEAN BEACHES

South Bunbury & Withers

Established streets close to the ocean beaches, schools and shops. Housing varies street by street, so it rewards a wander before you commit.

~5-10 MIN · GREEN & QUIET

East Bunbury & College Grove

Leafy and settled, close to the university campus and schools. Popular with families who want space without a beachfront premium.

~15 MIN · COASTAL ESTATES

Dalyellup

A coastal community to the south with newer homes, parks, its own college and a young-family feel. A slightly longer drive, and most people love the trade.

~10-15 MIN · ESTUARY

Australind & Eaton

North-east across the estuary, with newer homes, larger blocks and calm water for kayaking and crabbing. Great value for families.

~15 MIN · SPACE & TREES

Gelorup & the semi-rural fringe

Bigger blocks among the tuart and peppermint trees, the closest thing to a small farm within easy reach of work. A car is essential.



A neighbourhood playground in Bunbury in the golden hour: parks like this are a short walk from most homes

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Rent first, then buy

Almost everyone we help move here rents for six to twelve months before buying. Bunbury is a working port in a resources state, and the rental market can tighten when a big project is hiring, so securing somewhere for your first month before you fly, even short-term, makes the start much calmer.

Before you sign

- ☐ Confirm your work site, then map the drive at the time you would actually travel.
- ☐ Decide your water: ocean, bay, or estuary and inland.
- ☐ Check the school local-intake area for the exact address if you have children.
- ☐ Ask how the home stays warm and dry in winter and cool in summer.
- ☐ Visit the street at the time of day you would be coming home.

Getting around Bunbury

Bunbury is a fifteen-minute city in every direction. You will want a car for the South West, but you will hardly notice using it at home, and the drive to Perth is easier than most people expect.

Most trips around Greater Bunbury take ten to fifteen minutes, and parking is generally easy and often free, a small luxury that quickly becomes part of life. The local bus network, TransBunbury, runs town routes seven days a week and uses the SmartRider card; it is handy if you live on a route and work regular hours, though most clinicians on shifts drive.

The flat coastal and estuary paths are lovely for cycling and walking, especially along the bay and around the Leschenault Inlet. For weekends a car is part of the plan, because the wineries, forests, trailheads and beaches south of the city are the reason many people choose Bunbury in the first place.

~2 HRS · FORREST HIGHWAY

By road to Perth

A dual carriageway for most of the way. A Perth weekend, a concert or an airport run is an ordinary thing to do.

TRANSWA · BACK FROM MID-2026

The Australind train

The Perth–Bunbury passenger train returned in 2026 with new trains, and services are building up. Check Transwa's timetable and book ahead for busy runs.

TRANSWA

Regional coaches

Coach services link Bunbury with Perth and the towns of the South West, a useful option if you are between cars.

BUSSELTON ~45–50 MIN · PERTH ~2 HRS

Flying

Busselton Margaret River Airport has direct flights to the east coast on some days; most domestic and all international travel goes from Perth Airport.

JOURNEY	TYPICAL TIME
Across the city	10–15 min
Australind or Eaton → city centre	10–15 min
Dalyellup or Gelorup → city centre	~15 min
Bunbury → Busselton	~45–50 min

JOURNEY	TYPICAL TIME
Bunbury → Busselton Margaret River Airport	~45–50 min
Bunbury → Perth city centre	~2 hrs by car, ~2 hrs 30 by train
Bunbury → Perth Airport	~2 hrs



Perth, two hours north: close enough for a concert, a conference or a weekend in the capital

Your first month

- ✓ Sort a car early. The regional used-car market is smaller than a capital's, so give yourself time to choose.
- ✓ Check your licence conversion timeline with WA's Department of Transport soon after you arrive.
- ✓ If you live in Australind or Dalyellup, try the drive once at your real start time.
- ✓ Pick up a SmartRider if you plan to use the buses or the train to Perth.

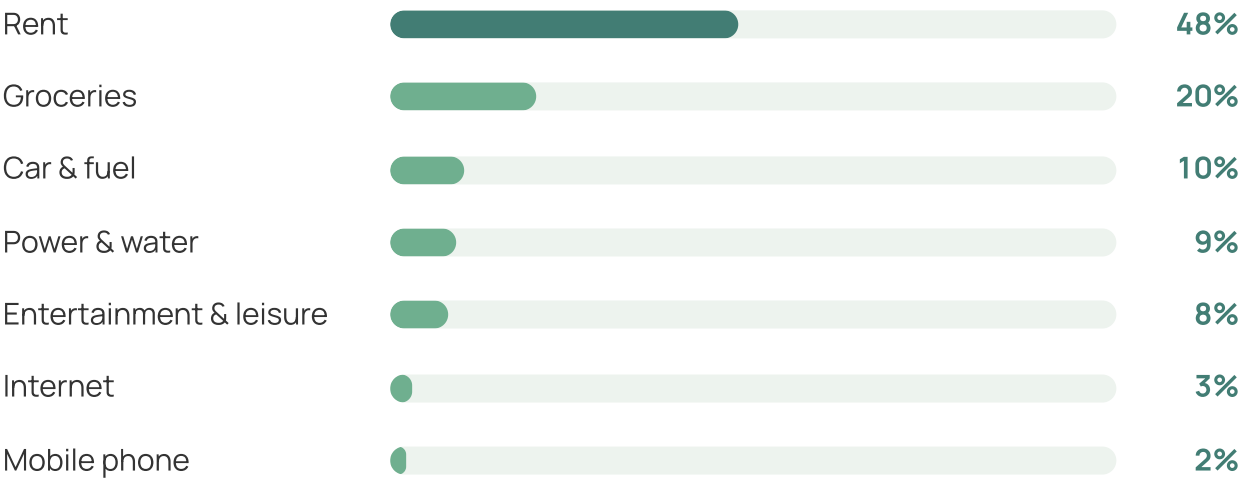
What it costs to live here

Bunbury’s big advantage is housing. Most everyday costs sit close to Perth’s, but the roof over your head costs materially less, and that difference adds up beautifully over the years.

We don’t print prices in our guides, because a figure that is right today can mislead within a year. What stays true is the shape of the budget. Groceries, fuel, insurance, power and phone plans cost much the same as in Perth: Australia is largely a national market, and Bunbury is big enough to have proper competition, so you won’t pay a regional premium on the weekly shop.

Housing is where the city shines. Renting or buying here costs noticeably less than in Perth, and a fraction of Sydney or Melbourne, which changes what a single clinical salary can carry. Add free parking, short commutes and fewer before-school care hours spent covering a long drive, and the month goes further than people expect.

Where a month goes



Proportions for one person on a mid-range budget, not amounts. Rent is still the biggest line, but here it takes a smaller share than in Perth, Sydney or Melbourne.

Worth planning for

- ✓ Flights home. Most international trips start with the drive to Perth Airport, sometimes with a night either side, so build that into your travel plans.
- ✓ A cosy winter home. A well-heated, dry house makes the rainy months a pleasure.
- ✓ A car, and perhaps two. The South West is best explored by road; many couples manage with one car for the first year.
- ✓ The setting-up period: temporary accommodation, a bond of up to four weeks' rent plus rent in advance, and furnishing a home.



The best things here are free: a paddle on calm water costs nothing but an early start



Surf, swims and sunset walks make weekends go a long way

IN SHORT

- ✓ Think of Bunbury as Perth prices for everyday things, with a noticeably more affordable home.
- ✓ Short commutes and free parking quietly save both time and money.
- ✓ Plan ahead for flights home via Perth, and enjoy the beaches, bay and trails that cost nothing.



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

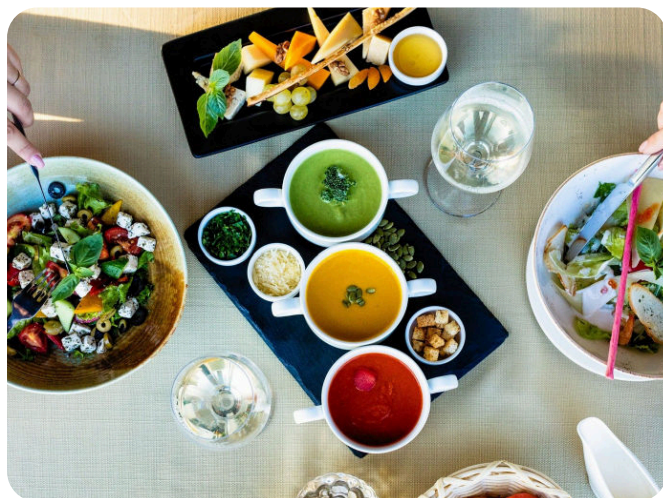
What I tell people about Bunbury

Bunbury is one of those places people underestimate on the map and fall for in person. When I talk to clinicians about it, I start with the work: a referral centre for a whole region, with a breadth of cases and a level of responsibility that you would wait years for in a big city department. For imaging professionals especially, the chance to work across modalities is a real gift for your career.

Then I talk about the life. Ten minutes to work, dolphins in the bay, a farmers' market that becomes your Saturday morning, and Margaret River as an ordinary weekend rather than a once-a-year holiday. Families tell me they finally have time for each other. If you want room to grow at work and room to breathe at home, with Perth close enough for everything else, I would love you to come and look.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



New friendships often start around a shared table



Weekend brunch, the South West way

Food, shopping and the everyday

The real test of a place is how an ordinary Wednesday feels and whether Saturday morning has a rhythm. Bunbury does well on both, helped along by one much-loved market.

The Bunbury Farmers Market is the place locals mention first. It is a large, indoor produce market open seven days a week, packed with fruit and vegetables from South West growers, along with cheese, bread, meat, seafood and deli counters. The South West is the state's rain-fed food bowl, and having its produce on your doorstep makes cooking at home a pleasure rather than a chore.

Eating out is better than the size of the city suggests: good coffee, casual seafood, pubs and wine bars, and a cluster of restaurants along Victoria Street and the Marlston waterfront. The range of cuisines is smaller than a capital's, but Indian, Thai, Japanese, Vietnamese and Chinese restaurants are all here, and Perth is close for the occasional special trip.



Weekend brunch is a South West institution



Cooking the food of home is easy with a couple of specialist grocers in town



A glass among the vines: wine country is half an hour inland

HOME BY EVENING

Weekdays

A short commute leaves time for a swim, a walk or the kids' sport after work. People say this is the change they notice most.

MARKET, THEN THE WATER

Saturday morning

Produce and coffee at the market, then whichever beach the wind favours.

~30 MIN INLAND

Saturday afternoon

Lunch or a tasting in the Ferguson Valley, close enough that it never needs planning.

SOUTH, OR SLOW

Sunday

Busselton and beyond for a proper day out, or a quiet walk by the estuary.

Bunbury is friendly and easy to join. The Bunbury Multicultural Group runs shared meals, festivals and events that bring newcomers and long-time locals together, and the South West Multicultural Festival is a highlight

each year. There is an active Malayali community through the Bunbury Malayalee Association, and congregations across many faiths. Clinicians often tell us the professional community feels close too: you get to know the colleagues you refer to, and that makes the work feel personal.



Groceries from home

The main supermarkets stock a growing range of international foods, and Bunbury has Asian and Indian grocers for the essentials. For anything very specific, many people combine an online order with an occasional stock-up trip to Perth. Our local directory lists where to start.



Thai, Vietnamese, Chinese and Japanese restaurants are all part of the local mix



South West fruit makes breakfast at home a pleasure



Western rock lobster, a celebrated catch along WA's coast



Sushi and Japanese food are easy to find in town

What people do at the weekend

You are living at the top of the South West, the corner of Western Australia that everyone else drives hours to reach. Weekends here are outdoors, unhurried and close to home.

In the city itself, the weekend often starts on the water. The Dolphin Discovery Centre on Koombana Bay has an interaction zone where, on many mornings, wild dolphins swim in close to the beach, and boat cruises head out on the bay. Back Beach and Ocean Beach are for surf and long walks, Wyalup–Rocky Point has its striking dark basalt shoreline, and the sunset from the Marlston Hill lookout is a local ritual.

On calmer days families head to the Koombana Bay foreshore, with its sheltered swimming and big waterfront playground, or paddle and crab on the estuary. When it rains, there is the Bunbury Regional Art Gallery in a beautifully converted former convent, a full programme at the regional entertainment centre, the library and the city's indoor pools.



People drive four hours from Perth for the weekend you get by driving thirty minutes.

IN TOWN

Koombana Bay dolphins

A resident pod of wild bottlenose dolphins, a discovery centre and eco cruises. Locals stop counting the sightings.

~30 MIN INLAND

The Ferguson Valley

Rolling green hills, small wineries, breweries and farm-gate produce, plus the quirky gnome village that children adore.

~45–50 MIN

Busselton & Geographe Bay

Calm, shallow water and the famous jetty, perfect for young children when the surf coast is lively.

~50 MIN INLAND

Collie & the forest

Purpose-built mountain-bike trails, dams, bushwalks and the giant mural on Wellington Dam.

~5-10 MIN

The estuary & mangroves

Kayaking, crabbing in season and a boardwalk through the state's southernmost mangroves.

SPRING

Whale season

Humpbacks and southern rights pass the coast on their migration, with the best viewing further south around Cape Naturaliste.



Green vineyard country: wine regions sit within half an hour to ninety minutes of Bunbury



Camping weekends in the forest and on the coast are a South West favourite



Breakfast at camp: forest campgrounds are an easy drive inland



Quokkas on Rottnest Island, off Perth: a favourite long-weekend trip

Around Bunbury

Bunbury isn't just near the South West; it is in it. Wine country, forest, the calm waters of Geographe Bay and the great surf coast of Margaret River are all day trips.

Head south along Geographe Bay and in under an hour you reach Busselton, where the timber jetty runs nearly two kilometres out over turquoise water, with a little train along its length and an underwater observatory at the end. Keep going and Dunsborough's sheltered beaches lead to Cape Naturaliste, with its lighthouse, coastal walks and some of the best whale watching in the state in spring.

Turn south from there and you are in the Margaret River region: world-renowned cellar doors and restaurants, limestone caves, towering karri forest, surf breaks that host international competition and the Cape to Cape Track running the length of the coast. It is close enough for a day trip and lovely enough for many long weekends.

Inland, the Ferguson Valley's green hills are thirty minutes away, and beyond them Collie and Wellington National Park offer mountain-bike trails, dams and quiet forest. Perth, with its tertiary hospitals, concerts, sport and international airport, is about two hours north.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Back Beach & Ocean Beach (nearest beach)	~5 min	Bunbury's own ocean beaches: surf, long walks and sunsets, with calmer swimming on the bay side at Koombana Bay.
Victorian Alps ski fields (nearest snow)	~4 hr flight + ~3-4 hr drive	The nearest ski fields are a flight east to Melbourne, direct from Busselton on some days or from Perth, then a drive into the mountains: a lovely winter holiday.
Perth (nearest major city)	~2 hrs	The state capital: tertiary hospitals, concerts, sport, shopping, Kings Park and the beaches of the metropolitan coast.
Perth Airport	~2 hrs	Domestic and international flights; Busselton Margaret River Airport, about 45-50 minutes south, has some direct east-coast flights.
Koombana Bay dolphins	In town	Wild bottlenose dolphins, a discovery centre and eco cruises right beside the city centre.
Busselton Jetty	~45-50 min	One of the world's longest timber-piled jetties, with a jetty train and underwater observatory.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Dunsborough & Cape Naturaliste	~1 hr-1 hr 15	Sheltered bays, a lighthouse, coastal walks and spring whale watching.
Margaret River	~1 hr 15-1 hr 30	Wineries, surf, caves, karri forest and the Cape to Cape Track.
Ferguson Valley	~30 min	Rolling hills, small wineries, breweries and farm produce.
Collie	~50 min	Mountain-bike trails, dams, forest walks and the Wellington Dam mural.



The Busselton jetty on Geographe Bay, about 45–50 minutes south of Bunbury

~1 HR 15-1 HR 30

Margaret River region

Cellar doors, long lunches, surf beaches and caves. Many families make it a monthly ritual.

~1 HR 15

Cape Naturaliste

The lighthouse, Sugarloaf Rock and clifftop trails, with whales offshore in spring.

~40-50 MIN

Wellington National Park

River pools, forest campgrounds and walks along the Collie River valley.

~30 MIN

Tuart Forest National Park

A rare forest of tall tuart trees near Ludlow, on the way to Busselton.

~1 HR NORTH

Mandurah

A waterside city on the way to Perth, with canals and estuary cruises.

~2 HRS + FERRY

Perth & Rottnest Island

A long weekend in the capital, with a ferry to car-free Rottnest and its quokkas.



Spring wildflowers and grass trees in Western Australian bushland



Kings Park in Perth, about two hours north: an easy weekend in the capital



Kangaroos are a common sight on country drives and at dusk on the edge of town



Elizabeth Quay in Perth, two hours north: an easy city weekend



Mettams Pool on Perth's northern coast, a calm snorkelling spot for a weekend in the city

Families and schools in Bunbury

Bunbury is a lovely place to grow up: beaches and parks on every side, sport for every age, short school runs and a community where families quickly get to know each other.



Kindergarten in WA is usually part-time and often based at the local primary school



Calm bay and estuary water makes paddling an easy family habit

Western Australian schooling starts with Kindergarten, a part-time, non-compulsory year for four-year-olds, usually at the local primary school. Pre-primary is the first compulsory year, then primary school runs from Year 1 to Year 6 and secondary from Year 7 to Year 12, ending with the WA Certificate of Education (WACE) and, for university entry, an ATAR. The school year runs from early February to mid-December across four terms.

There are three sectors. Public schools are run by the WA Department of Education and enrol by local-intake area, so your address decides your guaranteed local school. Catholic schools are run through Catholic Education Western Australia and the Bunbury diocese, and independent schools, many of them faith-based, set their own enrolment and fees. Well-established names in the city include Bunbury Senior High School, Bunbury Catholic College and Bunbury Cathedral Grammar School, with public senior high schools and colleges in Australind, Eaton and Dalyellup too.

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School fees on a temporary visa

Western Australia charges dependants of many temporary visa holders a fee to attend public schools. For the common skilled work visas it is a yearly fee charged per family rather than per child. Check the current rules for your visa on the WA Department of Education's information for children who are dependants of visa holders before you plan your budget, and ask your employer whether they can help.

Choosing a school

- ☐ Check the local-intake area at the exact address using the Department of Education's Schools Online finder before you sign a lease.
- ☐ Look at school profiles on the My School website, then visit or ask for a video call.
- ☐ Ask about English as an Additional Language or Dialect (EAL/D) support if your children are new to English.
- ☐ Uniforms are bought from the school's uniform shop or the local uniform supplier the school names; many uniform shops also sell good second-hand items.

What children tend to love here

- ☒ Watching the dolphins at Koombana Bay and the Dolphin Discovery Centre.
- ☒ Surf lifesaving 'Nippers', swimming lessons and summer days on the Koombana Bay foreshore playground.
- ☒ Big Swamp Wildlife Park and the boardwalks through the estuary's mangroves.
- ☒ Gnomesville in the Ferguson Valley, and the jetty train at Busselton.
- ☒ Mountain-bike trails at Collie and in the local bush.
- ☒ Club sport for every age: Aussie rules, soccer, netball, cricket, basketball, hockey and more.

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Early childhood

Before Kindergarten there are long day care centres, family day care and playgroups across Greater Bunbury. The Australian Government's Child Care Subsidy can reduce fees, but eligibility depends on your visa, so check with Services Australia early, and join waiting lists as soon as you know your suburb.



After the bell: school days end early enough for the beach



Play-based learning is at the heart of early childhood in Australia

SOUTH WEST CAMPUS · BUNBURY

Edith Cowan University

A university campus in the city, with courses including nursing, education and business, and pathways to study in Perth.

BUNBURY CAMPUS

South Regional TAFE

Vocational training across the South West, including health and community services, plus free English classes for eligible migrants.

~2 HRS NORTH

Perth's universities

The state's full range of universities, including medicine, imaging and allied health, is within reach for older children.



Bunbury trades the size of the department for the size of the life, and most people never look back.

Your Bunbury address book

Bunbury is a friendly regional city where newcomers are noticed and welcomed. The Bunbury Multicultural Group brings people from many backgrounds together through shared meals, festivals and storytelling projects, the Bunbury Malayalee Association keeps Kerala's culture alive with an annual Malayalam fest, and churches, a mosque and an Orthodox parish serve a growing mix of faiths. For anything not yet represented locally, Perth's large communities are two hours north.

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City of Bunbury

Bins, libraries, pools, parks, events and services for the city and its inner suburbs

bunbury.wa.gov.au

Shire of Harvey

Council for Australind and the northern side of the estuary

harvey.wa.gov.au

Shire of Dardanup

Council for Eaton and the Ferguson Valley

dardanup.wa.gov.au

Shire of Capel

Council for Dalyellup, Gelorup and the coast to the south

capel.wa.gov.au

TransBunbury

Bunbury's town bus routes, timetables and fares

13 62 13 transregional.wa.gov.au

Transwa

The Australind train and regional coaches between Bunbury, Perth and the South West

transwa.wa.gov.au

healthdirect

Free 24-hour health advice from a registered nurse, anywhere in Australia

1800 022 222 healthdirect.gov.au

Visit Bunbury Geographe

The region's visitor site: events, beaches, food and things to do

visitbunburygeographe.com.au

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Bunbury Multicultural Group

Volunteer-run, not-for-profit group organising events and projects across Bunbury Geographe and the South West, including 'Dine With Me' shared meals, the 'This is Me' migrant stories project and festival events. Its website keeps a directory of local community groups.

bunburymulticulturalgroup.com.au

Bunbury Malayalee Association (BMA)

Malayali community association celebrating the culture of Kerala, with festivals and an annual Malayalam fest at the Dalyellup Community Centre. Contact through its Facebook page or the Bunbury Multicultural Group's community directory.

South West Multicultural Festival

Bunbury's annual celebration of food, music and dance from the region's many cultures, held by the City of Bunbury; a lovely first outing for new arrivals.

bunbury.wa.gov.au

Adult Migrant English Program (AMEP) at South Regional TAFE

Free English classes, with childcare, for eligible migrants at the Bunbury campus and other South West campuses. Ask for the AMEP team.

1800 675 781 southregionaltafe.wa.edu.au

Multicultural Services Centre of WA

Settlement support and referral for migrants, with help to access housing, education, health and employment services; listed in the Bunbury Multicultural Group's local directory.

Office of Multicultural Interests (WA Government)

Services directory and a statewide community events calendar, which lists South West festivals and association events.

omi.wa.gov.au

Bunbury Multicultural Group

The group's Facebook community, linked from its website, for event news and connecting with other newcomers.

facebook.com/groups/126979640702

St Patrick's Cathedral (Catholic)

The cathedral of the Catholic Diocese of Bunbury, at 11 Money Street in the city centre, with weekend Masses. The diocese website lists parishes across Greater Bunbury, including Dalyellup.

bunburycatholic.org.au

St Joseph Syro-Malabar Parish, Perth

There is no Syro-Malabar Mass centre in Bunbury yet; the Perth parish's nearest centre is in Kwinana, south of Perth. Ask the Bunbury Malayalee Association about local gatherings.

syromalabarperth.org.au

St Boniface Cathedral (Anglican)

Bunbury's Anglican cathedral at 33 Parkfield Street, with Sunday services at 8am and 10am and open daily for prayer.

08 9721 3970 bunburycathedral.org.au

Bunbury City Church (Pentecostal)

Welcoming Pentecostal church at 1 Rose Street, Bunbury, with Sunday services at 10am.

bunburycitychurch.org

Calvary Assembly Church (Foursquare)

Pentecostal Foursquare Gospel church at 64 King Road, East Bunbury, with Sunday services at 10am.

calvarybunbury.com

St Nicholas Greek Orthodox Church, Bunbury

Greek Orthodox parish serving Bunbury and the South West.

Bunbury Mosque (Islamic Association of Bunbury)

The South West's mosque and Muslim community centre, with daily and Friday prayers, serving families from many countries.

Hindu temples, gurdwaras, Buddhist centres and synagogues

We could not confirm a dedicated temple, gurdwara, Buddhist centre or synagogue in Bunbury itself. The nearest are in Perth: see the Perth directory, and ask the Bunbury Multicultural Group about local gatherings.

Bunbury Asian Food Supply

Asian grocery in the Central Arcade, Stephen Street, in the city centre.

08 9792 4515

Spicy Superstore

Indian grocery at 22 Mondak Place, Carey Park.

India At Home

Online Indian grocery store that delivers to Bunbury.

indiaathome.com.au

Halal meat: ask at the mosque

The Bunbury Mosque community can point you to current halal options locally; Perth has a wide choice of halal butchers for stock-up trips.

Kosher food

There is no kosher supplier in Bunbury that we could confirm; the Perth Hebrew Congregation can advise on kosher food in Perth.

thephc.com.au

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Woolworths

National supermarket chain with several stores across Greater Bunbury; online delivery and click-and-collect.
woolworths.com.au

Coles

National supermarket chain with stores across Greater Bunbury; online delivery and click-and-collect.
coles.com.au

ALDI

Discount supermarket, good for a lower-cost weekly basket.
aldi.com.au

IGA

Independent local supermarkets in several suburbs and nearby towns.
iga.com.au

Bunbury Farmers Market

Bunbury's much-loved indoor produce market at 2 Vittoria Road, Glen Iris, open seven days, with South West fruit and vegetables, meat, cheese, bakery and deli counters. A sister market has opened at Vasse, near Busselton.
bunburyfarmersmarket.com.au

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Schools Online (WA Department of Education)

Find a public school and check its local-intake area for an exact address.
det.wa.edu.au/schoolsonline

Fees for dependants of temporary visa holders

WA Department of Education information on public school fees for children of temporary visa holders, administered by TAFE International WA.
tafeinternational.wa.edu.au/wa-government-schools/children-who-are-dependants-visa-holders

Catholic Education Western Australia

Enrolment information and school finder for Catholic schools, including those in the Bunbury diocese.
cewa.edu.au

Association of Independent Schools of WA (AISWA)

Peak body for WA's independent schools, with a school finder by region.
ais.wa.edu.au

My School

National website with profiles and results for every Australian school.
myschool.edu.au

School uniforms

Many Bunbury schools sell uniforms through their own uniform or clothing shop. Several local schools use Nell Gray, a uniform supplier with a store at 4/118 Spencer Street, South Bunbury. Ask the school office which applies.
nellgray.com.au

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realestate.com.au

Australia's largest rental and sales listings site.
realestate.com.au

Domain

Rental and sales listings, with suburb profiles.
domain.com.au

Flatmates.com.au

Rooms and shared houses, useful for the first few weeks.
flatmates.com.au

Bonds Administration (Consumer Protection WA)

Holds rental bonds in WA until the end of a tenancy; explains bond limits, lodging and releasing a bond.
consumerprotection.wa.gov.au/rental-bonds

Circle Green Community Legal

Free statewide tenancy advice for renters, including in the South West.
08 6148 3636 circlegreen.org.au

TransBunbury

Bunbury's town bus network: twelve routes running seven days a week, with timetables, maps and fares.

13 62 13 transregional.wa.gov.au

Transwa

The Australind train between Bunbury and Perth, back in service from mid-2026, and regional coaches across the South West.

transwa.wa.gov.au

Busselton Margaret River Airport

The nearest airport with scheduled flights, about 45–50 minutes south, with Jetstar services to Melbourne and Sydney on set days.

busseltonmargaretriverairport.com.au

Department of Transport: moving to WA

How to transfer or convert an interstate or overseas driver's licence when you move to Western Australia.

transport.wa.gov.au/licensing/drivers-licence/visit-move-wa

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Numbeo: Bunbury

Crowd-sourced prices to compare Bunbury with your current city; with fewer contributors than the capitals, use it as a guide alongside current rental listings.

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Bunbury-Australia

Numbeo: Perth

Useful for comparing Bunbury with the state capital.

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Perth



Checked October 2026

Community groups, shops and pages change. If a link has moved or you know a group we should add, tell us and we will update the guide.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The national services every newcomer uses, wherever in Australia you land.

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Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time
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Emergency from a mobile

Also connects to emergency services from any mobile phone
112

healthdirect

Free 24/7 health advice from a registered nurse
1800 022 222 [healthdirect.gov.au](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au)

Lifeline

24/7 crisis support and suicide prevention, by phone, text or chat
13 11 14 [lifeline.org.au](https://www.lifeline.org.au)

Poisons Information Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned
13 11 26

Pregnancy, Birth and Baby

Free support for parents from pregnancy to preschool
1800 882 436 [pregnancybirthbaby.org.au](https://www.pregnancybirthbaby.org.au)

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Medicare · Services Australia

Enrolment, cards, claims and reciprocal health care agreements
132 011 [servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare)

healthdirect service finder

Find a GP, pharmacy, urgent care or hospital near you
[healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services)

privatehealth.gov.au

Compare private health cover independently; run by the Commonwealth Ombudsman
[privatehealth.gov.au](https://www.privatehealth.gov.au)

Private health insurance complaints

The Commonwealth Ombudsman's free complaints service
1300 737 299 [ombudsman.gov.au](https://www.ombudsman.gov.au)

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Department of Home Affairs

Visas, skilled occupation lists and processing times
[immi.homeaffairs.gov.au](https://www.immi.homeaffairs.gov.au)

ImmiAccount

Lodge and track your visa application online
online.immi.gov.au

Register of migration agents (OMARA)

Check an agent is registered before you pay
[mara.gov.au](https://www.mara.gov.au)

Ahpra

National registration and the National Boards
1300 419 495 [ahpra.gov.au](https://www.ahpra.gov.au)

Fair Work Ombudsman

Awards, pay rates and your rights at work
13 13 94 [fairwork.gov.au](https://www.fairwork.gov.au)

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NSW school finder

Government schools and catchments in New South Wales
[education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder](https://www.education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder)

Find my school (Victoria)

School zones for any Victorian address
[findmyschool.vic.gov.au](https://www.findmyschool.vic.gov.au)

Find a school (Queensland)

State schools and catchment areas
qld.gov.au/education/schools/find

Find a public school (WA)

Western Australian public schools and local-intake areas
wa.gov.au/service/education-and-training/school-education/find-public-school

School zones (South Australia)

Zone maps for government schools
education.sa.gov.au/parents-and-families/enrol-school-or-preschool/zones-catchments-and-capacity-management/maps-school-zones-enrolment-year

Find your local school (Tasmania)

Intake areas for Tasmanian government schools
decyp.tas.gov.au/learning/find-your-local-school

Priority enrolment areas (ACT)

Find a Canberra public school for your address
act.gov.au/education-and-training/find-a-school-and-enrol

Choose a school (NT)

Urban and remote schools in the Northern Territory
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/choose-a-school

Starting Blocks

Compare childcare services and quality ratings near you
startingblocks.gov.au

Child Care Subsidy

Eligibility, rates and how to apply
servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy

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Australian Taxation Office

Apply for your tax file number (TFN), tax and super
[132861 ato.gov.au](http://132861ato.gov.au)

Moneysmart

Free, independent budgeting, super and banking tools
moneysmart.gov.au

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TIS National

Free interpreting by phone, 24/7, in 150+ languages
[131450 tisnational.gov.au](http://131450tisnational.gov.au)

Settle in Australia

Home Affairs' settlement topics and services for new arrivals
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia

MyAus app

Government app to help newcomers find services, in many languages
myausapp.com

Overseas drivers (Austroads)

How overseas licences are recognised, with links to each state's licensing authority
austroads.gov.au/drivers-and-vehicles/overseas-drivers/country-recognition



Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not registered migration agents.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to Ahpra registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

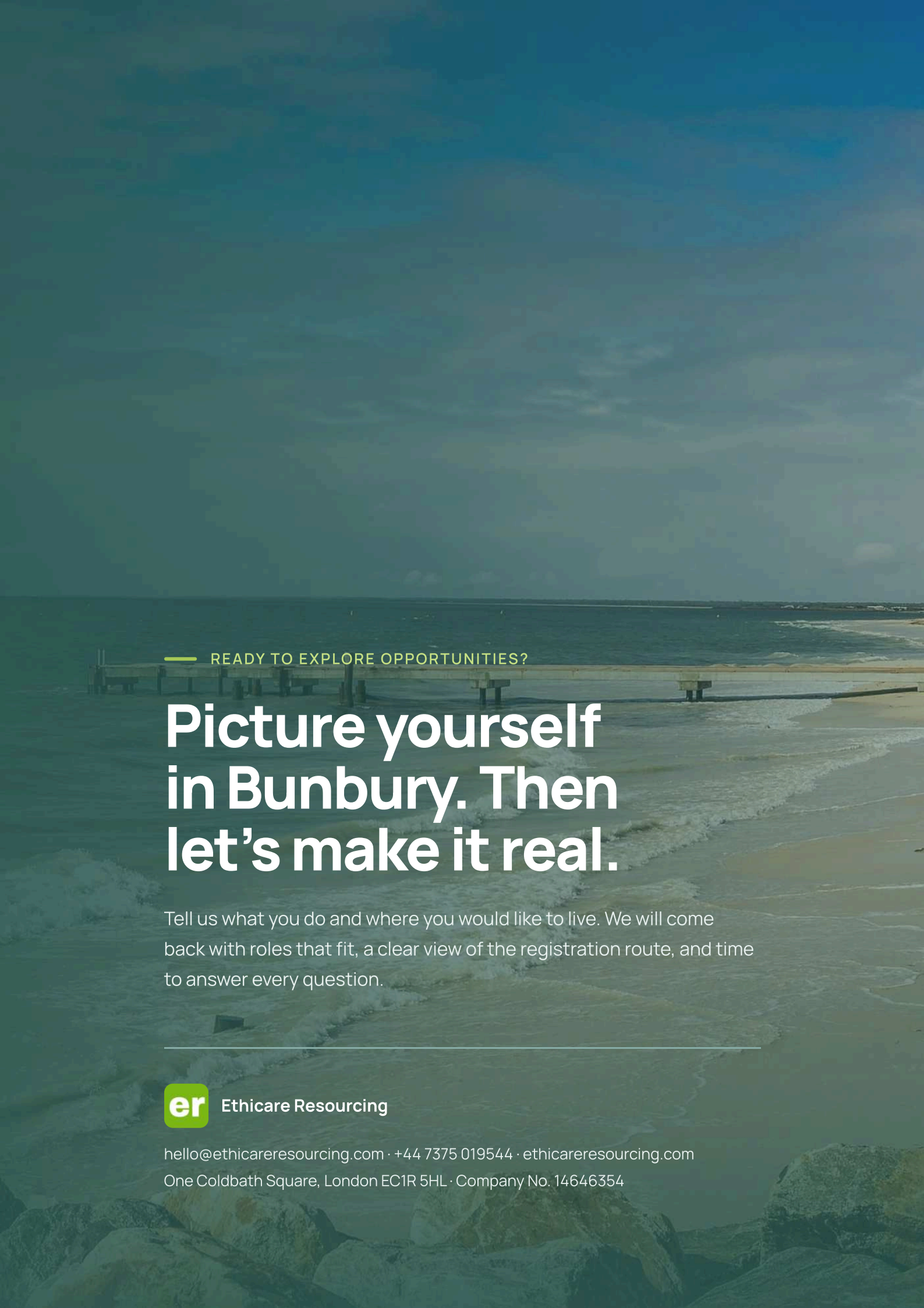
Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.



— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Bunbury. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, a clear view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



Ethicare Resourcing

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